

THE SKY IS (NOT) THE LIMIT

Advancements in drone tech like image processing, endurance and cutting-edge sensors can make a big impact across industries

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Perhaps the most exciting aspect of the drone story is where they're headed in the future. Drones have already become an integral part of defence, have become a sport in their own right, and are getting increasingly popular in media production. Let's have a look at some of the most useful areas where upcoming advancements in drone tech are all set to make a huge impact.

BRINGING THINGS TO YOU

Perhaps the most obvious area to benefit from drone deliveries would be ecommerce and logistics. According to a McKinsey survey in 2017, 86% of customers who abandon their shopping carts do so because of expensive shipping costs. Among products that are abandoned in online stores, critical items such as medication and groceries rank high. As of now, numerous players in this area including Amazon and UPS are testing drone services that would help them reduce shipping costs, especially for last mile deliveries.

Take the example of Amazon Prime Air, a conceptual plan to implement drone deliveries by the ecommerce

giant. In their demonstration back in 2016, an autonomous drone was able to complete a delivery within 13 minutes of the order being placed, without any guidance whatsoever apart from the product actually being packed and provided to the drone. Drone tech has improved since then, with better location awareness and navigational control. In the future, it would not be surprising to see logistics vehicles roll into your neighbourhood, and a bunch of drones taking off from it to complete a certain chunk of deliveries in the area while the driver fulfils other orders. Once the order has been completed, these drones will be able to find their way back to the vehicle or to the fulfilment centre, as

programmed. Such a system, tested by UPS, improves the efficiency and reduces fuel use for the delivery truck, allowing more orders to be completed in lesser time.

Concerns in this area include damage to the product, as evidenced by a Walker Sands survey in 2017, according to which customers were least willing to have electronics and luxury goods shipped via drones. On the other hand, even the Civil Aviation Ministry of India last year mulled the possibility of drone deliveries in India. However, as recent regulations both abroad and in our country point out, there's still some way to go before they can be implemented on a large scale. Also, you wouldn't be the only

one to think that there's not too much scope for innovation here other than simply improving navigational and image processing capabilities – a Gartner projection pins ecommerce drone deliveries at 1% of drone usage by 2020. Where it will matter though, is where fast delivery tim-



Amazon Prime Air